East India Company and the GIPR to lay a 21–mile ‘Experimental Line of Railway’ from Bombay to Thane.

On the eastern front, it was Rowland MacDonald Stephenson who submitted to the East India Company the first traffic and engineering feasibility report for a line from Calcutta to Mirzapore, leading to the establishment of the East Indian Railway (EIR) Company in May 1845. He became the first agent and managing director of the EIR. Four years later, a contract was signed to construct and operate a 161–km–long ‘Experimental Line’ between Calcutta and Rajmahal, which would later be extended to Delhi via Mirzapore.

As both companies raced to complete their lines, a few dramatic incidents, a combination of ill luck, miscalculation and land issues led to the delay of the east coast line. In the end, Bombay won a dramatic victory .

CHALLENGES THAT THE ENGLISH ENGINEERS DID NOT FORESEE

The plan to build the rail lines taking into account all kinds of pressure groups, individual promoters, survey reports and arguments both in favour of and against the construction of railways in India seemed to have failed to deal with all aspects of railway construction here.

That is not to say that the planning was not detailed. One would be surprised to read old records on how meticulous the British were and how thoroughly they conducted their research and planning, to the extent that a few administrators, promoters and investors went on to calculate the return of every penny invested in the proposed railways in India. It was a practical approach to building a practical railway. But the problem was not just related to engineering on unfamiliar terrain. There were problems of harsh weather conditions and related complexities, rigid local customs, superstitions that sometimes led to grave issues and lack of know-how at the grass-roots level, as it was the first time that something like a railroad was being set up on a large scale.

One official letter written by a director of the East India Company to the Governor General of India lists six reasons why the railways in India were thought to be difficult to lay, due to ‘peculiarities of the climate and circumstances’ of the country and how they should first be tried on a limited scale. The *Railway Register Journal* published in London in 1845 wrote an